

Prehistoric animals

The first signs of life appeared more than 3.5 billion years ago when tiny single-celled organisms evolved in the oceans. Over millions of years, other organisms evolved, moved on to land, and even took to the air.

IN THE AIR

Many prehistoric creatures took to the air. They included pterosaurs, such as *Dimorphodon* and *Eudimorphodon*, which were flying reptiles. As time passed, birds and flying mammals also appeared.



IN THE WATER

Prehistoric seas were full of life. Early organisms such as *Wiwaxia*, *Opabinia*, and *Anomalocaris* seem very strange to us. However, later fossil fish such as *Megalodon* and *Hybodus* look a lot like the fish and sharks around today.



TYPES OF PREHISTORIC ANIMALS

We use the term "prehistoric" for creatures that existed before recorded history. They were very diverse. The dinosaurs are probably the best known and most familiar, but there were also fish, invertebrates (animals without backbones), reptiles, amphibians, and mammals.



INVERTEBRATES
This squid-like belemnite lived in the prehistoric oceans some 200 million years ago.

SCIENTISTS THINK THAT EITHER AN ASTEROID STRIKE OR ERUPTING VOLCANOES CAUSED A MASS EXTINCTION OF PREHISTORIC ANIMALS